EMPATHY IN ACTION

Anthology of Short Stories and Essays

2024 July Edition

Dear Readers,

Our July Newsletter is finally ready! This special issue features captivating stories and essays from emerging writers, curated with care by the VSA Team. It includes a mix of fiction and non-fiction that explores the depths of human connection and understanding.

Esteemed researcher Prof. Simon Baron-Cohen noted in his book Zero Degrees of Empathy, "...empathy itself is the most valuable resource in our world. Given this assertion, it is puzzling that in the school or parenting curriculum empathy figures hardly at all..." In line with this, volumes of neuroscience research now show that nurturing the empathic circuits in our brains makes us more peaceful, healthier, and resilient. Recognising others' feelings enhances our relationships with family, friends, and colleagues.

Each piece in this issue showcases students' deep understanding of empathy's importance in our world. These stories embody the spirit of empathy in action, reflecting our commitment to fostering a more compassionate and connected society. Enjoy these inspiring journeys and let them encourage you to embrace empathy in your own life.

We invite you to explore this edition and share your favourite pieces with us, explaining your choices to have your vote counted for the Readers' Choice Award. Let’s support our dedicated writers and spread the ripple of empathy by inviting friends, colleagues, and family to read the entries. Together, we can celebrate the power of empathy and its transformative impact on our lives and communities.

Each year, when we open submissions for the Elaine Hobson Memorial Literary Festival, we confront the challenge of ranking entries. Despite blind marking, it's ironic to judge these essays and creative pieces, as art is inherently subjective, and every judge has their unique perspective. We congratulate the selected top four but firmly believe every entry is a winner.

To all writers, if your name isn't on the winners' list, don't be disheartened. Be proud of your work. We thoroughly enjoyed reading your stories and essays. Most importantly, continue writing meaningful pieces that will inspire our global community. Our next Global Empathy Conference will commence in May 2025 at the University of California, Silicon Valley. If you would like to participate, share your next piece on empathy. Together, let's continue to explore the depths of human connection and inspire a global wave of understanding and compassion.

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2024 ELAINE HOBSON LITERARY AWARD WINNERS



FIRST PLACE : PARTHIVI KAPUR
TITLE: LUKA CHIPI

SECOND PLACE: PARTH VOHRA
TITLE: IN SEEING THE INVISIBLE

THIRD PLACE: ANNIKA JAIN
TITLE:
KEYS OF CONNECTION

FOURTH PLACE: RUBY HAND
TITLE: CAPTURED: A SNAPSHOT FROM THE STOLEN GENERATION

EMPATHY IN ACTION
Anthology of Short Stories and Essays

Congratulations to our talented writers who have shown remarkable grit in their pursuit of delivering unique and crucial messages of empathy to readers around the globe. These authors have demonstrated the skill to compose narratives that deeply explore the powerful human quality of empathy.

I applaud their commitment and the passion-driven motivation to induce positive change in the human condition. Our young writers and entrants to the Elaine Hobson literary festival have been identified as highly competent in the craft of narrative composition. Every student who submitted their writing has been acknowledged, and we are so proud of you all.

Please keep in touch with Virtual School Australia website to watch out for details about the next literary festival and VSA's upcoming events that you can be part of. Keep sending ripples of empathy within your communities.

Liz Bawden
Literary Festival Director
Rajashree Imandi, Editorial Team Leader
Elaine Hobson Memorial Literary Festival

READERS' CHOICE FORM: https://forms.gle/UMZQheCGLbhZRtvK7
Thank you in advance, and happy reading!



PC_ Liz Bawden

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ECHOES OF EMPATHY

Empathy is the art of walking a mile in someone else's shoes, even if they're three sizes too small and covered in glitter.“There is nobility in compassion, beauty in empathy and grace in forgiveness.” Empathy is the most important ingredient to a good humane life. Compassion and forgiveness cannot happen without empathy. There’s something divine about the purity of this realization- the fact that one can perceive, understand and feel what another person is experiencing. Life is all about this mysterious connection with each other. This feeling of oneness. Of being one big family and experiencing what may be called universal consciousness. While one might understand empathy, it is common to confuse it with “sympathy”. While sympathy refers to sincere concern for someone who is experiencing something painful, empathy refers to stepping into the shoes of the other person and looking at life from their perspective. Empathy can be from helping a dear one during their tough times by sharing your own experiences and understanding their challenges to look at the world from the perspective of a five-year-old and helping them understand the little things in life. Life is like a necklace, full of colourful beads but what holds them together is the thread of empathy. Without a good quality thread, the beads scatter all around. Therefore It is one of the most essential charms in the life of a human being.

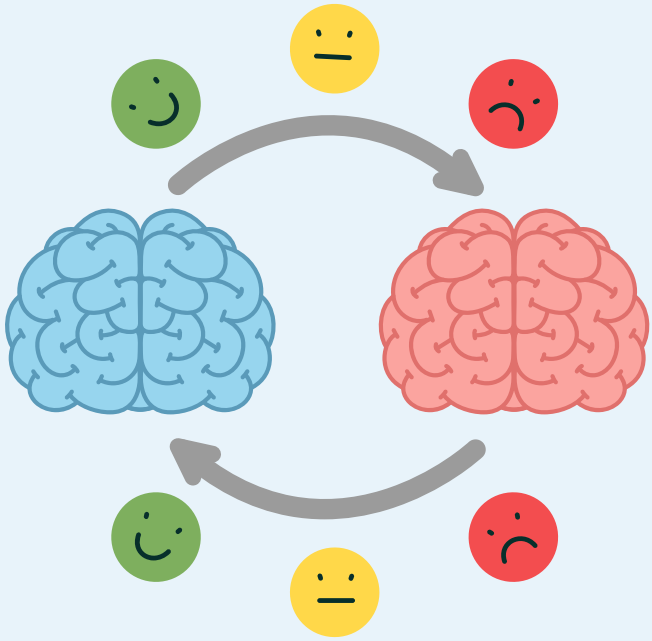
In today's rapidly advancing technological landscape, human connection has become increasingly scarce. The gap between people is increasing and the bonds are becoming superficial, instead of talking to one another now people prefer to find solutions off the net. Difficult to say if our virtual reality is taking over us or vice versa because reels and Instagram stories have engulfed our experiences and validation in the forms of likes, comments and forwards decides our self-worth. People have lost touch with the idea of confiding with one another and creating meaningful connections. They are trying to cover up their problems by indulging in social media 24/7. Furthermore, it's vital to find the true meaning of empathy as it is a humane quality. It is what one feels through the heart and not through the mind.

Empathy serves as the cornerstone of human connection. It helps recognise the diversity within relationships and plays a crucial role in fostering understanding, compassion, and cooperation. Empathy promotes effective communication and conflict resolution helping build authentic relationships with people. It is evolving as a human being. It’s like fitting into a foreign mould and feeling like it’s your second skin. Empathy is regarded as a virtuous quality, it plays a significant role in shaping an individual's personality and influencing connections and interactions around them. It’s the ability to relate to and connect with people to empower and inspire their lives, helping address social issues, bridging gaps nurturing a more cohesive and supportive global community.

ECHOES OF EMPATHY

Life is an enigma and a mystery unsolved. It's not about just inhaling and exhaling but breathing the humanness. Reading the unwritten, listening to what hasn't been spoken, and feeling what hasn't been expressed. A man without empathy is like music without rhythm, a canvas without colour and a body without a soul. Empathy is empowering to perceive and believe what the other says and wants. And when one believes then one achieves. Let's just be empathetic and the rest like a consequential ripple effect will spread positivity, happiness and oneness.

By Aanya Jain
Year 11
Springdales School Dhaula Kuan,
New Delhi, India



Exploring empathy was a deeply engaging experience which gave me the opportunity to realise how empathy is one of the most essentials charms in the life of a person. Contemplating its essence led me to recognize empathy as the catalyst for embracing the diverse spectrum of thoughts within our society and uplifting each other to build a brighter future for generations to come. - Aanya Jain

RIPPLE EFFECT

I sighed loudly as I entered our cramped room in an unremarkable Marriott... our quarantine for a fortnight. How depressing! “Welcome to Singapore, Aarav." 'Embrace the new' is true only for those not forced to call a new country home and live through the ennui of a school with no friends; evenings with no cricket; and surroundings with no familiarity. Stepping out of quarantine, I resolved to get out of this spiral. Nudged by my mom, I concluded that it had to be in the form of .... swimming, an activity quintessential to Singapore. Little did I know that my tryst with Coach Jay was to change my attitude towards life. Or for that matter, his.

Despite being an avid sportsman and a state-level cricketer, swimming did not come naturally to me. Gagging while ingesting water, flailing my limbs and defying buoyancy was rather humbling. Rather ironically, I felt like a fish out of water, almost ready to give up. Coach Jay’s encouragement “Keep trying, it will get easier” only served to infuriate me further. Noticing this, he shared his journey and struggles with me. He grew up in the Philippines, was naturally aquatic, and won many tournaments. Just when he felt he was at the top of the world, he had to move to Singapore, where he could not compete anymore due to his nationality. Instead of wallowing in grief, he adapted and took up coaching, as helping kids become better versions of themselves motivated him. “Even now, I miss competing and wonder ... but I do not regret it.”

This shared empathy of new surroundings and lost avocations became a cornerstone of our relationship. He understood my challenges of moving to a foreign land, giving up my passion, and learning a new skill. And I found motivation in knowing that I am not alone in facing challenges.

6 months later

“Take your marks!” the referee yelled.

I saw my coach in the crowd, cheering me on. He had his own Aquathlon later in the day, but here he was, having pushed me nonstop for the past few weeks, for mine. “3...2...1... GO!” Gasping, I stumbled across the finish line. The adrenalin of winning a medal overrode any lack of sensation in my exhausted legs or pulmonary vessels. The framed photo of my coach and me holding up our respective medals, rejoicing in our age-unconstrained bond and learning from each other’s journey sits proudly on my bookshelf. A prouder digitally captured moment, though, resides alongside it. That of Aryan - a cheerful nine-year-old holding up a bat gingerly, celebrating his first century.

Coach Jay inspired me to put behind my insecurities and learn a new skill – not only swimming but coaching!

RIPPLE EFFECT

I am now an assistant coach at Singapore Cricket Club for the U12s, helping kids pick up cricketing and life skills – through empathizing with them, rather than through any training manual. The circle of life continues and I am proud to contribute in whatever way I can.

By Aarav Aggarwal
Year 9
Singapore American School
Singapore

It was a fulfilling process for me; I felt that I discovered a lot more about myself through writing this and I appreciate how it allowed me to express my feelings through words. The highlight for me was definitely when I finished my final draft and the piece turned out to be much better than I had originally planned, everything flowed together and worked well. It was challenging to fit my story into 500 words, it forced me to be direct and only keep what was essential, but the word limit helped me write a better story in the end as it made the important parts shined through.

- Aarav Aggarwal

A Question for you:

What is the difference between empathy and sympathy?

a) Empathy is feeling sorry for someone, while sympathy is understanding their emotions.

b) Empathy is understanding and sharing someone's emotions, while sympathy is feeling sorry for them.

c) Empathy and Sympathy are interchangeable terms.

d) Empathy and Sympathy refer to the same emotional state.

EMPATHY CHAINS: PAY IT FORWARD

Empathy is a powerful force that forms the backbone of public and personal relationships. It is widely known that empathy is fundamental to maintaining healthy relationships because it ensures that the needs and worries of each party in the relationship are adequately addressed. Even so, empathy goes beyond strengthening relationships: it can improve the world. Small, daily acts of empathy have the potential to enact impressive change, both in the public and private spheres.

In 2011, Japanese figure skater Yuzuru Hanyu was participating in the ice rink when the Great East Japan Earthquake—with a magnitude of 9.0—caused a tsunami in the region of Tohoku and led to massive destruction. Hanyu's ice rink was flooded but not destroyed; Hanyu's home, however, sustained damage, forcing Hanyu and his family to relocate to a temporary shelter. In the aftermath of the earthquake, Hanyu found himself unable to skate and "seriously thought about quitting" (Goh). The thing that changed his mind? Fellow figure skater Shizuka Arakawa's encouragement and donation. With Arakawa's support, Hanyu continued to skate. It gave back to the Japanese community affected by the earthquake through generous donations and ice skating performances dedicated to the survivors of the disaster. Arakawa's empathy—which might have felt minor in the moment—moved Hanyu so deeply that he, too, decided to exercise his empathy and pay it forward. The deep-seated effects of empathetic acts are evident: one singular, very personal show of empathy can spiral into multiple empathetic moments that touch the lives of thousands and make visible improvements in the world. Empathy becomes a chain.

Does the chain of empathy only form in the context of life-altering catastrophes? Of course not. For many economic migrants working to support their entire family, their empathy is born from unfortunate but everyday circumstances, not a discrete disastrous event. In India, many people move from villages to cities for opportunities to improve their quality of life. I have personally seen this happen with my paternal grandfather, who migrated from his village to better his own life. After establishing himself in the city, my grandfather, conscious of the ongoing struggles in his siblings' lives, lifted his loved ones by bringing them to the city and opening a new world of opportunities for them. My grandfather's siblings, touched by his empathetic act, perpetuated empathy by then lifting others from their community in poor circumstances, replacing the cycle of poverty with a cycle of empathy. In this way, most migration is driven by chains of empathy that begin with one person seeking a better life and then empathizing with and helping others attain that better life through economic migration. Even in private situations away from public pressure, empathetic acts are still cyclical and chain-like, repeating themselves because they have such a profoundly positive impact on people and the world around them.

Although more noticeable in life-changing calamitous situations, empathy is and should always be present in people's relationships with one another.

A simple, seemingly inconsequential act of empathy or kindness towards just one person can elicit a series of empathetic acts that lift entire communities. Does that not show the incredible power of chain empathy in bettering the entire world?

By Ananya Parandekar
Year 10
American School of Bombay
Mumbai, India

I learned more about my family and specific family members through this process, which was definitely the highlight of this essay writing process. I was also able to explore empathy through several different lenses and understand myself better through the personal anecdotes I considered including. The most challenging part of this process was finding my unique voice and integrating robust perspectives on empathy into the essay.

- Ananya Parandekar

A question for you:

2. Which of the following is a potential benefit of cultivating empathy?

a) Improved mental health and well-being

b) Enhanced problem-solving abilities

c) Increased cooperation and collaboration

d) All of the above



KEYS OF CONNECTION

In an apartment above the hustle of the city, the melodies of a piano danced through the air, playing the notes of an age-old symphony. Inside was a young woman, completely absorbed in her music.

Her name was Lila; a college student, and pianist on the side. As the last dregs of notes rippled away, she returned to her surroundings, back in the throes of life. She typed a quick caption and hit the post on the video she was taking. Lila doubted her followers would feel her music as she did. No one ever did.

Unbeknownst to her, in the apartment underneath hers, an old woman sat in her chair, rocking it to the echoes of Lila's music. Time had etched its mark on Mrs. Thompson; her once slender, pianist's fingers were now crooked and bent, aching with arthritis.

One evening, as Lila played, she heard a gentle tap on her door. She went to open it, only to find Mrs. Thompson standing there, her eyes shimmering with unshed tears. Immediately, Lila ushered her in.

"Your music," Mrs. Thompson said, her voice quivering. "'Beautiful' does not do it justice. It's a gift; reminding me of a time when I was just like you."

Touched, Lila smiled, her heart bursting with the emotion in the other woman's words. "Please come in. You must tell me more. Did you used to play the piano as well?"

Mrs. Thompson smiled, her eyes crinkling with laugh lines. "Yes, indeed. Not to brag, but I was quite the sensation." Then, she sighed despondently, looking down at her fingers. "Until old age made itself known. Once I got arthritis, well...I couldn't play anymore."

Lila's chest spasmed with the thought of never being able to play the piano again. It was a constant in her life, her escape from reality. Losing it would leave a feeling akin to drowning in the seas. The pain Mrs Thompson must have felt must have been unbearable.

The old woman herself had fallen silent, looking at the piano in Lila's room longingly. Immediately, Lila came to a resolution.

"Why don't I...play for you, Mrs. Thompson?" she offered hesitantly. "You could give me a piece to play, and I could learn it in time for tomorrow."

Mrs. Thompson's eyes lit up at once. "You would do that for me?" she said, her hands shaking with excitement. "Oh, I would absolutely love it!"

Emboldened, Lila went further. "Would you like to come to my apartment every couple of evenings...make a tradition out of this?"

And so it began.

Every three evenings, Mrs. Thompson would arrive at Lila's apartment. They would spend hours just listening to Lila's music, forming a bond that surpassed the language of words.

In the final chapters of Mrs Thompson's life, Lila's melodies became more than just music; they were a testament to the enduring strength of empathy, a beacon of light in the darkness, and a reminder that even in the face of adversity, love and compassion could prevail.

By Annika Jain
Year 10
Oberoi International School
Mumbai, India

The highlight of this experience was writing my story and bringing what was originally a vague idea to life on paper. I enjoyed experimenting with my writing, using different ways to describe my characters, building up their personalities, and reflecting the main idea of empathy in my story. Although it was challenging, the satisfaction I felt at the end of the process made the struggles worthwhile.

- Annika Jain

A question for you:

3. Which brain imaging technique is commonly used to study empathy?

a) Magnetic resonance imaging (MRI)

b) Positron emission tomography (PET)

c) Electroencephalography (EEG)

d) Functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI)

DEFENDING DENISE

As I sat in the classroom on the second day of the new year, memories flooded back to me like an unexpected gust of wind, reminding me of my struggles with language barriers when I first moved here. A cool breeze swept over my face as I looked up to see Denise enter through the door. You could tell she was different from the lot. She had curly locks that hung from her face, and big eyes full of wonder. However, there was an undeniable barrier - she didn't speak English.

Professor Kashyap's entrance brought a shift in the atmosphere, his authoritative demeanour casting a shadow over the room. His gaze lingered on Denise, a sardonic smile playing at the corners of his lips. "Settle down, class," he declared, his tone dripping with sarcasm. "We have a newcomer today, though it seems she missed the memo that this is an English class."

Denise, undeterred by the professor's barbed remarks, retrieved her notebook, her determination unwavering. Yet, as Professor Kashyap directed his mocking words towards her, a sense of unease settled over the room like a thick fog. "How exactly do you plan to understand what I say, missy?" he taunted, his voice laced with condescension. Denise met his gaze with a mixture of confusion and defiance, her inability to comprehend his words apparent to all.

She scanned the room and fixed her gaze on me. Amidst the tension, a silent plea echoed in Denise's eyes, a cry for help that tugged at my heartstrings. I exchanged a sympathetic glance with her, a wordless gesture of solidarity. I didn’t know what to say.

He looked at the rest of us and snickered again. “For those of you who do understand English, today’s class is on the use of idioms in literature. And dear Denise, you can just while away time, doing something the rest of us can’t do.” He turned his back to the board and started writing the excerpts. I quickly looked at Denise and saw that she was pushing back tears and looking dejected.

I kept wondering what I should do. Prof. Kashyap was known for his difficult attitude and lack of empathy for his students. Denise was a student in an exchange program, and I was in charge of making sure she assimilated. The recollection of my challenges adjusting to a new language and culture intensified as I watched Denise's plight unfold. I felt a sudden surge of indignation. With resolve coursing through my veins, I approached Denise, my steps purposeful. I held her hand and urged her to come with me and together, we made our way to the staff room, where Professor Kashyap was engrossed in his affairs. Ignoring his dismissive glance, I turned to face him, my voice steady as I spoke.

DEFENDING DENISE

"Denise is brilliant," I asserted, my words imbued with conviction. "She may not speak English fluently, but it doesn't make her any less of a person."

By Anoushka Tandon
Year 9
Dhirubhai Ambani International School
Mumbai, India

The best part was showing how I began to care more about Denise and eventually stood up for her. It felt incredibly rewarding to write about kindness and defending others. The hardest part was ensuring the story felt genuine and not like a lesson on being nice. I wanted readers to experience empathy naturally, without it feeling forced.

- Anoushka Tandon

A question for you:

What is Empathy?

a) Understanding, sharing someone else's feelings and taking action.

b) Understanding and manipulating someone's emotions.

c) Feeling indifferent towards others.

d) Ignoring others' perspectives.

THE EMPATHY CODE

Does empathy merely entail placing yourself in somebody's shoes or can it be a deeper multifaceted cognitive experience that extends beyond this universal axiom?

Empathy allows parents to forgive the erroneous behaviours and decisions of a child by overshadowing feelings of lividness and disappointment that may trivialize the child's emotions. They thus react through the consideration of these underlying feelings rather than their seemingly disproportionate surface behaviour. Empathy helps establish an unwavering bond of trust between children and their parents, allowing them to express their qualms and troubles devoid of fear of judgment. It is proven that children shown empathy are more likely to mend their ways. For instance, my irascible nature compelled me to speak disparagingly and through unpleasant gestures when fortune avenged me. My empathetic parents did not react harshly, aware I had poor control of these actions in the heat of the moment. Instead, a constructive conversation, where I was advised to take deep breaths in a calm composure like the Buddha statue grinning at me from the countertop in support, was carried out. Additionally, I succumbed to peer pressure and began using social media without my parent's knowledge, who vehemently protested its usage. Once caught, my empathetic parents did not rupture the roof with betrayed cries of "You lying scoundrel", and "How dare you disobey us". Instead, they understood that social pressures were difficult to resist while doling out 'archaic wisdom' irrelevant today. This incident epitomised compassionate empathy, wherein one is concerned for the other to understand their emotion without necessarily experiencing them. It is beyond cognitive empathy which if succinctly defined is just understanding one's perspective.

Empathy transcends communication barriers, allowing one to recognize unspoken emotions and create a supportive environment for the other through comforting gestures or words. It distinguishes hearing and truly resonating, building a rapport with the other. "Notorious troublemakers" are empathetic towards parents too. On returning from work, they pat them affectionately, asking how their day went. This conveys sincere gratitude and concern to the rejuvenated parent. Well, so empathetic that they immediately clamour for the latest PlayStation or inquire about how much further the stock market has plunged. Parents may display unjustified lividness while undergoing harrowing circumstances. Empathetic children are not displeased but give them moral support with the maxims "Everything will be fine", and "I understand you are stressed, may I help". This is emotional empathy where one resonates with the others' deep-rooted emotions and experiences them such as grief or stress here.

Empathy helps annihilate social inequalities, conflict and other petty differences but fosters ethical values, fortifying the betterment of our world. We become oblivious to the wrongdoings and anomalies of others. Synonymous with

universal brotherhood, it brings about commonalities. Could you imagine a world where empathy is rampant? Businesses would incorporate sustainable materials into products despite the costs, prioritizing the environment. Those afflicted by mental health issues would cease to be lambasted but encouraged by others, who would focus on the root cause of their issue, to seek assistance, making them feel worthy and heard. Empathy could break the shackles of the bigots' mind by allowing him to feel the anguish of the victim and contest the purpose, reward and impact of his actions. The quavering pleas of the scarred will penetrate the ruthlessness of those political leaders who dismiss the ubiquitous corpses in the soil to their greed for ambition, power and imposition of ideology.

While empathy is pivotal towards meaningful relations and a better world, I would like to conclude with the quote, “Empathy without boundaries is self-destruction”. We must be empathetic but ensure it is not exploited or drains us.

By Arsham Hirani
Year 12
The Cathedral and John Connon School
Mumbai, India

My highlight about writing this essay was to remember the importance of empathy and how I often take this quality which others selflessly display towards me for granted.
Arsham Hirani

True or False?

Empathy is solely a human trait and cannot be observed in other animals.

a) True
b) False

SEE YOU AT HOME

Melted cheese glued to a pizza box. Baked beans at the bottom of a sharp-edged tin. A heavily worn T-shirt. I was too busy surveying pickings from the night's garbage hunt to throw more than a glance your way. Still, the wrinkle of your nose and the quickening of your stride, at least as much as you could without snapping your new heels, said it all. I turned back to the garbage; I'd heard those words thrown at me enough times before, living on the streets. Admittedly, I did wonder if I'd seen a hint of recognition in your eyes, but I didn't blame you if not – you had more important matters to think about. I still recognise you. I always had, but every time you passed by on your way to a warm home, a soft bed, and a loving family and I slunk back to my cardboard abode, I knew it meant nothing.

My cardboard home was now buried under heaps of rubble. In all my time living on the streets, however hard it got, I'd always had somewhere to call home. However damp, dangerously exposed, or repulsive it was, it was mine. It was a comforting thought: however much the chasm between me and your ivory towers ripped itself apart, that was still something we shared. Now, standing in the red-brick ashes of the building I'd sheltered in, a cold dread washed over me as I realized it had been severed.

In the weeks that followed, did you notice I wasn't around anymore? If you ever caught my fleeting presence, were your bones, too, taken over by the same creeping smoke damp of city mud that seemed to constantly drip through my skin? Reduced to a wisp of a thing by clawing hunger, I wandered aimlessly on the tail-ends of rotting garbage scents - scents that made you sick to your stomach and stole your appetite - hoping to find a meal.

When the weeks had long since dragged themselves into months and the weather turned to a vengeful force beating burning sunlight down onto passersby, I found myself cowering under the slender shade of a windowsill. As the sidewalk seared my skin through, I glanced upwards in search of clouds. Instead, I was greeted by a face, encircled by brilliant sunlight, peering out from an upstairs window. Your face. Just as soon as I saw it, though, you were gone. Vanished, back into your air-conditioned palace. I should have known.

But I didn't. I couldn't have been further from the truth, because there you were again. Only this time, it was both of us going back into your home. Our home? Finally, I had been seen. The door opened with a creak to a room, covered in golden sunlight, that seemed to stretch into infinity. I was home. Smiling, you set me down. "I've always wanted a cat."

By Azadeh Changrani-Rastogi
Year 10
Dhirubhai Ambani International School
Mumbai, India

It shows the reader first-hand, an important component of empathy: that one can and should have empathy for anyone, regardless of their identity, situation, or what one knows about these. It also serves to cause readers who may have adverse reactions to realizing that the subject was a cat to question certain attitudes they may have and to, hopefully, actively incorporate more empathy for all into their lives.

Azadeh Changrani-Rastogi

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF EMPATHY

Epictetus, a Greek philosopher, once said “We have two ears and one mouth so we can listen twice as much as we speak,” imitating the idea of how intertwined individuals’ lives are with empathy, which is defined as the ability to not only perceive the feelings of others, but to feel them in accordance, and to respond to them with compassionate action. Empathy and its application are innately crucial in understanding human emotion and in functioning as a thriving society, without which our world would be overwhelmingly and unnaturally cruel. Even with the growth of technology and the blinding obstacle of hatred and fear, the persistence of acting with compassion and with moral and altruistic empathy, combatting feelings and inclinations of indifference or even revenge, illustrates how intrinsic empathy is to human nature.

In 1996, an African-American 18-year-old woman named Keshia Thomas was participating in what started as a controlled rally against the Ku Klux Klan, when people noticed a “white middle-aged man wearing a Confederate flag T-shirt”* with an SS Tattoo. The now angry mob “became barbaric” with anger according to Thomas, and she decided to physically shield him from the blatant violence, putting herself through pain for someone who may not have done the same for her. Thomas, speaking on the mob mentality stated that “people who hurt... they come from hurt”, portraying remarkable human empathy, illustrating how “the biggest thing you can do is just be kind to another human being”. The powerful choice that Thomas made to protect life through kindness exhibits the significance of empathy in the face of blinding anger and an ‘eye for an eye’ mentality, striving to break the endless and dehumanising cycle of hatred and revenge that continuously prevails today.

Empathy is what stops the world from dividing into a hierarchy where people are separated based on their beliefs and ideals. It prevents the world from falling into a vengeful chaos where we dehumanise one another, reducing ourselves to versions of superficial worth, a world without compassion for other beings where we push species to the brink of extinction for our selfish gain. Already, the modern world is moving scarily towards apathy, a place where we burn forests to the ground for exploitive gain of oil or land resources, where we desensitise ourselves to the realities of the world around us with a quick swipe of our finger, promoting an idea of blissful ignorance to replace one of truth.

The lens through which humans see the world, empathy is how we connect with the people around us. We are slowly but surely forgetting our intrinsic need for empathy and the vital role that it plays in humanity, moving towards a reality of isolation and competition, looking away and walking past without hesitation as someone next to us trips and falls to their knees, feeling fictitiously autonomous until we, too, fall. We forget how we observe and understand the flaws and

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF EMPATHY

imperfections; the tiny, precious idiosyncrasies unique to each individual, and how that recognition makes us feel seen and bridges connection. We forget the simple empathy we experience through an art piece's invocation of emotion, standing up for others in principle, or even something so seemingly minute as wishing someone a "get well soon" when they fall sick. We forget the importance of feelings of love and understanding; and what it means to be human.

By Ishita Bansal
Year 12
French International School of Hong Kong
Hong Kong

I really enjoyed writing about the concept as it is something that everyone has an experience with, and it made me learn a lot about ideals and the human nature, so I really enjoyed that.
Ishita Bansal



EMPATHY – THE CONNECTION THAT CURES

Empathy is the ability to accurately recognize others' feelings and understand the meaning of these feelings (Kalisch,1973) from their point of view. Sympathy, in contrast, is defined as "the feeling that you are sorry about someone else's trouble, grief, misfortune, etc". It puts the person struggling, in a place of judgement more than understanding.

Empathy can be classified into three types - "emotional", "cognitive" and "compassionate".

Emotional empathy is when you feel physically along with the other person, as though their emotions are contagious (Goleman, 1995). This type of empathy is especially relevant when it comes to building human connections.

Cognitive empathy is defined as the ability to understand one's mental state by imagining how one feels, recognizing others' emotions, and understanding their viewpoints. (Gladstein, 1983). An example of cognitive empathy is if a friend doesn't get a job they interviewed for. We can see that they are hurting and disappointed, and we can also understand why they would feel this way.

Compassionate empathy (also known as empathic concern) goes beyond simply understanding others and sharing their feelings: it moves us to take action, to help however we can (Bariso, 2018).

Empathy has profound implications for personal growth and relationships. It teaches us the value of listening, not just to respond, but to truly understand (Decety & Jackson, 2014).

In my own life, empathy has been the bedrock on which I have forged deep relationships and conceived meaningful initiatives.

One of my friends had once felt ostracized and isolated at being constantly bullied at school. I comforted him, listened to him, and understood his plight. My empathetic support provided him with the much-needed courage to face up to his bullies. I have no tolerance for people being hurt for enjoyment, and to initiate change we teamed up to start the "Anti-Bullying Squad" at school. It has been our constant endeavour to ensure that no student feels that distressing sense of alienation - hoping we can provide them the support they need.

Historically, empathy has been the catalyst for social change. Consider the abolition of slavery, or the "Civil Rights Movement"; these monumental shifts were propelled by individuals who felt a profound empathy for those suffering injustices. Leaders like Martin Luther King Jr. harnessed empathy to unite people across racial divides, illustrating that empathy can indeed be a powerful tool for societal transformation (Goleman, 1995). Such events exemplify the ability of empathy to transcend individual experiences and become a collective force for good.

Today, the relevance of empathy cannot be overstated, especially in an era where polarization runs rampant. The global refugee crisis presents a poignant example of the necessity of empathy. Stories of families torn apart by war and persecution, demand a response rooted in empathy. It is empathy that moves individuals and

EMPATHY – THE CONNECTION THAT CURES

nations to open their doors and hearts to those in need, underscoring the role of empathy in addressing some of the most pressing challenges of our time (UNHCR, 2020).

Empathy is the crucial, yet invisible thread that binds humanity. It is a fundamental aspect of our existence that enables us to connect, understand and support one another. From the personal to the global scale, the value of empathy is undeniable. It challenges us to look beyond ourselves, to see the world through the eyes of others, and to act with compassion and understanding.

We must strive to cultivate empathy within ourselves and our communities, for it is through empathy alone that we find our common humanity, and it is through humanity, that we can make the world a better place for all.

By Kanishk Dasgupta
Year 10
Arya Vidya Mandir Bandra (West)
Mumbai, India

By learning the different perspectives on this subject from renowned psychologists, my mental horizon has broadened to a far greater extent than I could have imagined. It was enlightening to realize the power of empathy to heal and make meaningful changes in our world. This has piqued my curiosity on the subject, and I am keen to delve deeper into it in my high school.

Kanishk Dasgupta



THE CIRCLE OF LIFE

The sun's blaze ignited the jungle's vast expanse. On his right was a barren, lifeless tree. The black goliath-like mountains stood tall in the background, dwarfing him. The dried river was lined with dark boulders, its once-flowing waters now replaced by fissured earth and a half-eaten deer carcass.

The animals seemed quieter than usual, apprehensive. As he passed by, a mother langur whisked away her baby The birds stopped twittering. The deer looked at the rifle in his hands and froze. He trudged on. Beads of sweat trickled down his face, but he hardly noticed.

His mind wandered back... the evening before, he had returned home late, exhausted. He did not protest when the next morning, his 10-year-old offered to get water from the pond. The boy never returned. A search party returned with the bloodied remains: the tiger, Ravan, had killed the boy.

His wife remained inconsolable, oscillating between uncontrolled wailing and desperate sobs, hopelessness streaming down her eyes. She would never see that smile again, never hear that laugh. As for him, he didn't even shed a tear. Before grief could set in, his heart was aflame with murderous rage. Ravan had broken a fundamental law of the jungle; it had hurt a cub – his son. He vowed to do to the beast as it had done to his son.

The summer seemed never-ending. July had arrived, but the rain gods didn't relent. Animals looked emaciated; plants wilted dejectedly. Most of the watering holes were dry. Thorns kept getting stuck to his pants as if trying to slow him down, but his mind was set.

Soon enough, the watering hole came into sight. He hid behind some bushes, getting a clear view.

Suddenly, a rustling of leaves... and a soft growl. There it was – Ravan's unmistakable figure. The tiger softly approached from the other bank. As it looked up, he saw the hollow eyes. It looked frail; the orange fur had lost its sheen. It lumbered on, thirst burning its throat.

He craned forward, trying to get a clearer shot.

He had grown up with nature. The jungle had been his home; the animals were his best friends. But here was a monster that had mercilessly robbed him of his beloved son.

It bent towards the water, tongue outstretched.

He placed his eye behind the eyepiece and focused. He could see the tiger's face as if it was standing in front of him.

THE CIRCLE OF LIFE

How fitting a response to the death of his son, by the same watering hole. His finger grasped the trigger.

Just then, something stirred. Out of the blue, a soft pair of eyes emerged from behind Ravan – a cub.

He gasped.

Ravan licked its face and guided the cub to the water. They waded in, the little one hanging on to its father, at peace and enjoying each other's company.

He froze. The rifle fell, and he dropped to his knees.

A lump formed in his throat and a tear rolled down his face. He understood.

Keshav Mohta
Year 11
Dhirubhai Ambani International School
Mumbai, India

This story is an adaptation of a story I heard during my visit to Jim Corbett National Park, a tiger sanctuary in north India. The story is a classic case of growing conflict between man and nature. It allowed me to appreciate that even wild animals are not truly wild - their actions reflect a certain reality of the harsh life they face.

Keshav Mohta



A RACE GONE AWRY

When I started running in middle school, I was not fast at all. I never made the Junior Olympics team, I struggled to break through in high school and was always one step behind those who started earlier, but I had a dream. I can still recall the first time I watched the Olympics as a wide-eyed child, filled with wonder at the sheer magnificence of the athletes. And now I have my chance. Today, Tokyo presents an opportunity like no other, for me, Isaiah Jewett, to make the Olympic finals.

As I prepare at the starting line, my mind goes back to all the times I thought I couldn't make it and to every time I was on the verge of giving up and trust me - there have been many of those times. So, what got me through these times was not only my love for running but also my anime addiction. Once I start running, I channel cartoons. The minute that gun fires, I can enter my anime world, and execute my race. When the race gets hard, or in anime terms, when I get into the 'pain game', that is when the anime moment draws itself to life. While running, I get in a zone of being in an exact scene, re-enact it, and live through it. I've never been to Japan before, but really, this is my hometown, where nothing can stop me...

I cut that thought short as I hear the familiar command, "Go!", and a surge of adrenaline ignites as I burst from the blocks. Legs pumping, lungs burning, I find my rhythm amongst the pack, carving my path through the field. It is the first time in my life that I haven't felt nervous, and the excitement is fuelling me. I am now in second place, enough to secure my spot in the finals; all I have to do is finish in this position.

Suddenly, mid-stride, I feel a leg kick mine from behind, throwing off my balance. Time slows as I feel my footing slip away, and I tumble into the 'pain game'. I look back to see Nigel Amos, a fellow runner, also on the ground, and he is the one who tripped me. This is when I know I have lost, and the dream is over. But it's the same as anime, the main character always loses.

However, the thing is, those characters lose and then keep going, regardless of the failures. Those characters are exactly who I aspire to be... So I get up, pick up Nigel and say "Don't worry about it. Let's at least finish this thing" And that's exactly what we do, I put my arm around him, and through that, we create something bigger than an Olympic final, bigger than an anime adventure. That day, I realised the power of forgiveness, and how compassion will always take you further than material success....

By Krish Lambah
Year 12
The Cathedral and John Connon School
Mumbai, India

It helped me develop and refine my empathetic skills. I found myself actively imagining and understanding the perspectives and experiences of others, which contributed to my growth as a compassionate and empathetic individual.

- Krish Lambah

WHAT EXACTLY IS EMPATHY?

Empathy is defined as the action of understanding, being aware of, being sensitive to, and vicariously experiencing the feelings, thoughts, and experience of another. A key distinction which usually needs to be made is between empathy and sympathy. While empathy is shown in how much compassion and understanding we can give to one another, sympathy is more of a feeling of pity for another. Empathy is more important than sympathy as it involves a deeper level of understanding and connection with others. While sympathy involves acknowledging and feeling compassion for someone else's emotions or situation, empathy goes a step further by actively putting oneself in another person's shoes, experiencing their feelings and understanding their perspective. It fosters genuine connection, unlike sympathy which can often just be put on for show. The comparison itself outlines the importance of empathy, as some often use sympathy to judge a person's character when there could be no true feelings behind the outward display of affection.

However, empathy is a broad term and to truly understand its positive impact, it can be analysed through its socially prescribed three types: Cognitive Empathy, Emotional Empathy and Compassionate Empathy.

Firstly, cognitive empathy requires more logic, it involves understanding another person's perspective and recognizing their emotions without necessarily sharing those emotions. For example, take the example of a factory worker in a manufacturing plant who works long hours on repetitive tasks. To use cognitive empathy with Maria, a person would have to imagine themselves in her position, facing the monotony of the tasks, the challenge of focusing and the pressure to continue. By empathizing with Maria's experience, you can gain a deeper understanding of the challenges she encounters and empathize with her. If this skill is obtained and used, it makes one a better employer, coworker, or leader, depending on the situation.

Secondly, emotional empathy is the practice of sharing an emotional experience with another person and truly understanding how they feel. Recently, someone in my grade who had never been a close friend faced a family tragedy. Despite not being close friends, because of the visible impact on him, and the people around him, I was deeply affected by the loss. In such a situation, when someone is displaying signs of personal distress, you would consider the situation and compare their behaviour using your own experiences and then draw a pattern of their life to get to the issue. That is emotional empathy, essentially involving recognizing the emotions of others and motivating you to respond with kindness and compassion which helps create connections.

Finally, Compassionate Empathy: Is the ability to understand and share in someone else's emotions. To quote Atticus from 'To Kill a Mockingbird', "You never really understand a person until you consider things from his point of view... until you climb into his skin and walk around in it." People with compassionate empathy not only understand someone else's emotions but also feel a genuine emotional connection and concern for their well-being. They are motivated to offer support and assistance to those who are experiencing distress or hardship.

WHAT EXACTLY IS EMPATHY?

To conclude my essay, I would like to question, are these types of empathy really different? From what I've seen, there are significant overlaps and all three simply add up to the process of trying to make the world a kinder, more understanding and more compassionate place. Whatever type of empathy we consider, the real necessity is being able to understand others well and respond to situations positively. Empathy is the bridge that connects hearts and forms unity in a world that thrives on human connection.

By Krish Lambah
Year 11
The Cathedral and John Connon School
Mumbai, India

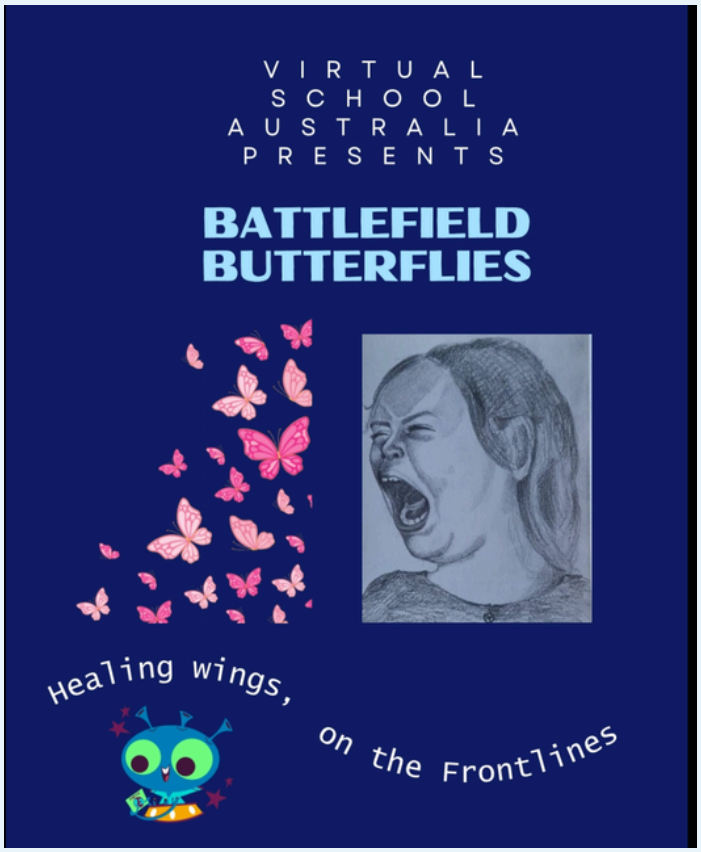
I really enjoyed writing about empathy because it helped me develop and refine my own empathetic skills. As I wrote about and imagined characters or situations that require empathy, I found myself actively imagining and understanding the perspectives and experiences of others, which contributed to my growth as a compassionate and empathetic individual.

- Krish Lambah

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FROM I TO WE

The news stole into the night, robbing our living room of air. My mum's choked sob as she hung up the phone shattered the disconcerting silence, confirming my dread. My Nani (grandmother), my marshmallow of comfort, who taught me to cook my favourite Daal makhani, my storyteller, and my closest friend, had relented to the pandemic's unforgiving wrath.

All sorts of emotions flooded me, from anger to sadness to self-pity. Watching my mother stoically and single-handedly organize the final rites of her one living parent within the shackles of the strict lockdown rules, it suddenly hit me - what if I had lost my mum? I grew up in that moment as I tried to get out of my wallowing to ease whatever little I could for my mother - even if it was just warding off the constant phone calls or fetching her a glass of water.

While all I wanted was someone to hug me and tell me everything would be fine, a greater force overrode my anguish, shifting my focus to my mother's, prompting me to think of how to alleviate it. I squeezed her tight to absorb whatever I could of her pain, grateful that she was with me. Coincidentally, we learned about empathy soon after, during online school, making me understand what I felt.

The pandemic, a cruel puppeteer, had yanked on the strings of lockdown, severing the connection with friends who could have offered a comforting embrace. The digital world was a flimsy medium failing to transmit the warmth of a hug or the solace of a shared tear. Realising how the virtual world and remote learning had isolated us, I now badly wanted to be around my friends and family- People! Anyone who gets me feels my pain and can just be with me. I was only twelve then, but I learned the immense value of human interaction. It's not the happy occasions that define us; I think the lows bring out our better sides. This gift of understanding the other person is a blessing that is irreplaceable by technology.

It became more apparent to me as people risked themselves to come over to pay their condolences. A single act of caring, a simple question of "Are you okay?" can power a cascade of support, a testament to the interconnectedness of human experience. I learned to care less for my gadgets and more for my people. My Nani, in her absence, had, as always, left behind a gift, introducing me to my empathic side.

Last year, my friend lost his grandmother – we were on a school camping trip when he received the shocking news. I felt his pain, and I, that once self-centred geek immersed in gizmos who awkwardly dodged human touch, hugged him. I packed his things as he sat there processing the news and comforted him. Upon return, I went over to be with him, helping him with missed school work and to find his way back to normalcy.

Over the last couple of years, I've learned to leverage my empathy beyond my immediate family and friends, giving off of myself to elevate the lives of underserved strangers and stray animals. The path of empathy can be challenging. It requires

pushing yourself out of your comfort zone, putting yourself in a vulnerable position, and opening yourself up to the pain of others. It may mean momentarily setting aside your needs to show up for another being. But in the grand scheme of things, isn't that a small price to pay to fill the world with compassion and understanding?

By Mohnish Bhadra
Year 10
Oberoi International School JVLR
Mumbai, India

i) The highlight was researching about empathy in itself. Through my research I was able to find very touching and inspiring examples of empathy and how it is displayed around the world. This made my day!
I loved exploring different ways one can be empathetic and try to apply it to myself as well.

ii) The most challenging part was trying to frame what exactly I wanted to say, though I knew about the situation and how I reacted, it took my a lot of time and effort in order to accurately phrase my feelings and emotions when I talked about my Nani and still fit it in the small word count.

- Mohnish Bhadra

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THE WAKE-UP CALL

The teacher sighed in resignation as she sat down on her chair. A piece of pastry was placed there by her students as a harmless ‘prank’. She knew it was more than that. “I’m disappointed in you guys”, she said and slowly composed herself, cleaned it off and began teaching. Not thinking about what would happen later at home. The sniggers of the students were soon silenced and were slowly replaced by attentive gazes. Despite their childish antics, she always taught her 5th grade class with extreme care, and the biggest smile on her face.

The next day she returned to class but something was amiss. “What was that on her face?”, a girl asked. “Did she fall?”, said another boy. Her face had a bruise, right by her temple, visible even through her makeup. “I live in the apartment next to her and I hear lots of fighting all the time. Her husband is really scary”, a voice piped up from the back. The whole class was silent. She resumed teaching with her usual smile, choosing to focus on her students. When the break finally arrived, she rushed out, her mind filled with a mixture of emotions.

The evening before

5 pm: She tries cleaning the pastry stains off her sari but to no avail. She puts the key in her door and turns it slowly.

5:15 pm: “Make me a sandwich”, her husband mutters. “What’s that stain behind the expensive sari I bought you, do you have no appreciation?”

5:30 pm: “Ice. Ice. And more ice the pain will go away” she bawled to herself.

"Come on, Meera, you've got this," she reminded herself as got ready for yet another day at school. "You've got to stay strong for those students,” the mantra echoed in her mind as she boarded the train. As she entered the classroom, she was met with darkness. Puzzled by what was happening she fumbled to switch on the lights. She did not know that what she would see next, would leave a mark in her heart forever. The students stood before her with bright smiles, holding a banner: "We're grateful for you." Colourful balloons with "We're sorry" floated around the room, "I made homemade brownies!" exclaimed a little girl. "And I brought cookies!" chimed in another student. Overwhelmed with emotion, the teacher's eyes welled up with tears of joy. "You kids have no idea how much this means to me," her voice quivered with gratitude. With her burdens lifted, leaving her feeling lighter, she realised that all that mattered was her students.

THE WAKE-UP CALL

If ten-year-old students can demonstrate emotional intelligence and empathy, then why can't we? Empathy isn't merely understanding someone else's situation; it's about responding with compassion. The teachers who tirelessly support us deserve our empathy and appreciation, and it shouldn't require a wake-up call for us to recognize that fact. Let's strive to emulate the empathy of these young students and show our gratitude and support for those who enrich our lives.

By Naisha Sahney
Year 11
BD Somani International School
Mumbai, India

This experience provided me with an opportunity to delve into the essence of empathy, recognising it as a quality that every individual must possess. Exploring empathy at its core was undoubtedly a highlight, offering insights that resonated deeply within me. However, crafting a story that could effectively convey these insights and make a lasting impact proved to be the most challenging aspect. Nevertheless, navigating through this challenge enabled me to refine my storytelling abilities and deepen my understanding of empathy.

- Naisha Sahney



LISTEN, ENGAGE, CONNECT: AN EMPATHY ESSAY

“The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in the service of others.”
~ Mahatma Gandhi

Empathy, the ability to comprehend and share another's feelings, transcends fleeting trends. Despite its contemporary perception, there are countless stories in ancient literature; a testament to its enduring importance. This ability to connect with experiences beyond our own isn't confined to a single culture or historical period. In a world often marked by differences, empathy offers people the power to build connections across borders and backgrounds. By embracing this quality, we can build bridges of compassion, not just within our own communities, but across the vast cultural and geographical landscapes that define humanity.

Leaders throughout history have demonstrated empathy as a potent force for good. Look no further than Mahatma Gandhi, the champion of India's independence movement. Guided by the philosophy of Ahimsa (non-violence and oneness), Gandhi advocated for the rights of his people and independence (1947). He preached compassion towards all beings, striving to mend divides between religious groups. His iconic quote, "You must be the change you want to see in the world," embodies his belief in empathy as a catalyst for social transformation and peaceful coexistence.

In China, the Dragon Boat Festival (Duanwu Festival) offers another poignant example of empathy. The festival commemorates the life and patriotism of the poet Qu Yuan. However, its deeper meaning lies in an act of empathetic care for all citizens. A legend states that upon hearing about Qu Yuan’s death, the local villagers, in a state of shock, feared that the fish would consume Qu Yuan’s body. To prevent this, they threw rice dumplings (Zongzi) into the river to distract the fish and stop them from devouring Qu Yuan’s remains. Although it was a simple gesture, the villagers displayed an act of empathy towards the poet, recognising his suffering and honouring his legacy.

In the Bible, the scripture further emphasises empathy. In Colossians 3:12, it urges us to clothe ourselves with "compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience," portraying empathy as a visible and integral facet of our character. Through his own suffering – the "pains and afflictions and temptations … and the sicknesses of his people" (Alma 7:11, 12) – he gained a deep understanding of human struggles, enabling him to "succour his people according to their infirmities."

Similarly, Buddhism underscores the importance of empathy for all living beings. The Buddhist Pali Canon contains many teachings on cultivating compassion, not just for fellow humans, but for plants and animals as well. The Buddha recognized empathy as the key to overcoming suffering, devoting his life to helping others navigate it. The Four Immeasurables – loving-kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity – represent the cornerstone of Buddhist teachings on fostering empathy.

The ancient Indian text Arthashastra underlines the significance of empathy in leadership. Chanakya, the author, writes "The king should be like a father to his subjects. He should be compassionate and understanding. He should always strive to do what is best for the welfare of his people." This emphasis on compassionate leadership influenced numerous prominent figures throughout history.

LISTEN, ENGAGE, CONNECT: AN EMPATHY ESSAY

The universality of empathy transcends all cultural and religious boundaries. In a world often driven by ideologies, conflict, and prejudice, empathy serves as a crucial tool for understanding others and fostering connections. It bridges the divides that separate us, paving the way for a more harmonious world. So the first step is to choose empathy. The second step is to Listen, Engage, & Connect. By embracing empathy, we can become a strong, understanding, inclusive, and shared humanity as global citizens.

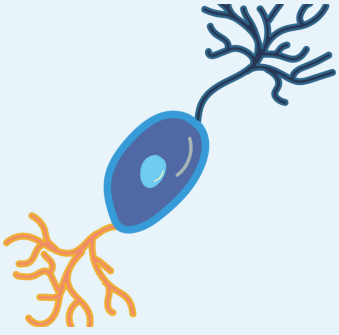
By Narayani Agarwal
Year 12
The Shri Ram School, Moulsari
Gurugram, India

I thoroughly enjoyed writing an essay on the topic of Empathy for this competition. It allowed me to dig deeper and research about the different cultures of the world. The most challenging part of the competition was to stay under the word limit of 600 words and keep the essay precise.

- Narayani Agarwal

FROM CARING COMES COURAGE.

LAO TZU (6TH CENTURY BCE)



TWILIGHT

To Ronak, for recounting this story, and inspiring me to pen it.

Jack:
It's cold tonight.

I scan the deserted street below rather pointlessly: no one ever strays here. No one ever will. The bitter, frosty winds screech, but they cannot hurt me: I am but a hollow reflection. I stroll closer still, gazing at the glimmer of ochre, azure and snow-building lights, and the tranquil lapping of the Hudson. The serenity almost makes me want to stay.

Slowly, I hoist myself over the railing, unwittingly plunging my hand into the shards of a shattered beer bottle. Numbly, I watch the crimson oozing out, softening hewn stone, and feeling nothing. Empty. Is it mine? Pressing down harder, serrated fragments piercing my palm, I vault across. Momentarily, I lean back, resting on the grille, letting my feet dangle over the alluring sidewalk, thirteen floors down.

I'll miss New York when I'm gone.

A candle burns at the edge: glinting in the wind, sparkling like the first day of spring. Desperately, I try to staunch gushing memories, but my heart yearns one last time.

Her. Holding hands and skating through avenues, staying up late texting, the way she'd laugh loudly at my corny jokes, and smirk at my obvious clumsiness, how she'd insist on buying me coffee every morning, always berating me for not sleeping enough, and the way her eyes lit up when she'd ask about my day. But most of all, I remember the sunset: how she'd grow cold, and rest her head on my shoulder, making my heart jump. It felt right. Felt like home.

It occurs to me that my actions tonight may not even make the morning news. Either way, I'm better dead than dead inside.

Chris:

He's out there again. I've seen him like this before, but never so far. It's her again, isn't it? María. I loved her too, you know? I get it, although he'd never believe me. There's something strange about a shared experience like this, a chasm of unforgettable memories that tugs at your heartstrings and slices them apart at the same time. Every rose has its thorns.

And so, I set out into the cold, every step weighing me down a little.

Epilogue: "Jack! What's up, cuz? Haven't seen you in a minute." Chris laughed.

TWILIGHT

Jack's eyes had a distant, haunted look to them. A pale yellow jersey stuck to him as if it feared forcible separation. Chris had always been good at hiding it. His eyes? Not so much.

A half-smile flitted across Jack's features. After a few moments of silence, he smirked, "I knew we'd go to the ends of the earth for her. But I didn't know we'd take turns standing at the edge."

Chris smiled quietly, "Guess it's my turn to remind us why we never actually jump."

The brothers embraced, taking in the sunlight over the memories they were forced to share, but had chosen to keep.

The candle beside them shimmered with the sunrise.

By Param Davda
Year 11
Dhirubhai Ambani International School
Mumbai, India

To me, the concept of empathy has been intrinsic to the development of human society. I've found that even the smallest acts of compassion in an environment like school have the potential to shape people's futures. The highlight was expressing myself on a topic that's deeply close to my heart: teenage suicide. I find it exceptionally devastating that so many students, especially in my home country (India), feel the need to succumb to social pressures, be it educational or romantic.
This piece allowed me to put myself into the shoes of one such individual and I was able to effectively reflect on how to better represent such characters in my works going forward. Most importantly, it allowed me to empathise with those afflicted with these difficulties.
- Param Davda

IN SEEING THE INVISIBLE

Invisibility – the fantastical superpower that often ruled the vast expanse of my imagination. A catalyst ready to propel the ordinary into a world of exceptional heroism. The pinnacle of science fiction that existed only within the confines of my juvenile psyche.

Or so I once thought.

To the exhilarating surprise of my childhood naiveté, invisibility appears all around us; a specimen of abundance, simply forced into obscurity by entitled ignorance. If only we cared to look, not with our eyes, but with our hearts, we would, in all its contradictory impossibility, truly see the invisible.

This invisibility lies in the protective truth behind a mother's concern. In every stern look that pierces my guilt-ridden smile when I return home way past my curfew. In every fierce scolding that follows late nights spent toiling over last-minute homework. In every chaotic flurry of arguments which descend upon the living room when I'm not allowed to go to a party. If only in those moments, I saw not through the trembling lens of my spectacles but the oscillating heartbeat of a loving mother, I would notice: the looming disquietude behind every stern look, the roaring ambition behind every fierce scolding and the passionate protectiveness behind every chaotic argument.

This invisibility lies in the unwavering duty of my school's security guard. In every sixteen-hour work day that spills into a river of sweat meandering down his forehead. In every conflict with disgruntled students who missed their bus that afternoon. In every train ride from the suburbs leaves families to wake up to an empty bed. If only in those moments, I saw not through the baggy eyes of a fatigued student, but the persevering limbs of an indefatigable breadwinner, I would remember: to share the last sandwich left in my snack box, to say thank you every time I leave the school compound, wish good morning to a man leaving home before sunrise.

This invisibility lies in the unspoken understanding of the Indo-Pak line of control in Kashmir. In every synchronised footstep that trudges in ankle-deep snow. In every knowing glance of resolute duty across unnervingly hostile borders. In every moment this hostility thaws to unmatched respect for unyielding national service. If only I saw not through closing eyelids watching the news but the steadfast stand of a fearless soldier, I would understand: not every enemy wants to fight a war, not every man across a border makes an enemy and not every border built by power-hungry politics dictates the terms of brotherhood.

IN SEEING THE INVISIBLE

Cognitive empathy, to know how others think and feel, to understand and value diverse perspectives; and emotional empathy, to feel a shared emotional understanding with another, each a lens in a pair of glasses far beyond the prowess of modern technology; which when worn make us aware; that invisibility, is not confined to the squares of a comic book, but ever present in the passions of those unsung heroes that curate the comfort we enjoy today.

Empathy may increase efficiency by 88%, or creativity by another 87%, but its true strength remains in its ability to unveil that glistening gossamer that forms an impenetrable network of love, kinship and fraternity, spanning every remote corner of our world, held together by those superheroes, who seek not glory, nor fame, whose ability is not a choice, but a consequence, whose secret identity remains forever guarded by that fantastical superpower that often ruled the vast expanse of my imagination - Invisibility.

By Parth Vora
Year 10
Hill Spring International School
Mumbai, India

This process helped me unlock a reflective attitude, in understanding that empathy goes far deeper than simply a sense of acknowledgement, and rather penetrates personal barriers and experiences. I was able to grasp a more holistic understanding of my own past experiences and to me, that was the highlight.

- Parth Vora



LUKA CHHIPI [HIDE AND SEEK]

August 5th, 1947, *Gujranwala* (*erstwhile Pakistan*)

Sounds of muffled giggling emerged from the cabinet, paling in comparison with the aggressive sloganeering outside the house. Geeta, all of seven years old, innocently combed her doll's silky hair with a makeshift comb crafted from a stick of cinnamon.

"Ma, look! I'm dressing my gudiya for school. See?" Geeta whispered, her brown eyes lit with innocence.

"Shhhhhh... Geeta beta, be silent," Damini peered out of a small chink in the cabinet, her quivering hand sliding over her daughter's head. Her sheer dupatta draped over Geeta's face, shielding her view. Geeta's tone dropped, "What happened, Ma? Where's Baba?" she asked, her tiny voice piercing through the cramped silence they sat in. "Beta, I told you, we're playing hide and seek. Now, quiet; we have to defeat Baba this time," Damini replied.

A mere sliver of light escaped through a crack in the cabinet doors. A cocoon of love and make-believe enveloped them, shielding them from the chaos outside that threatened to shatter their world.

Thuds echoed loudly, and the relentless pounding on the front door reached even the 4x4 cabinet, which sat 15 feet away from the house's main door. Menacing voices screamed demands of "Kholo!" (open up). Beads of Damini's sweat-stained the cabinet's red wooden bottom. "Ma, I'm feeling scared." Damini, with a reassuring touch, whispered, "Play with your dolls, it's just the wind."

Outside their sanctuary, amidst the conundrum of slogans, sat those who chanted them. '"Tch... What a stubborn lot. They won't just open up like this. Someone should go inside and coax them out," remarked one from the group. His rheumy eyes searched amongst the ranks of the kurta-clad that stood there, falling upon an unlikely candidate: a scrawny teenager. "You, it's time you become a man," he declared, pointing at the hesitant boy.

The boy, Farhan, stepped forward with a forced swagger. His feet heavy with reluctance and his teeth chattering in rhythm with the beat of his anxious heart. His head turned, and his gaze met the ominous mob behind him. Feeling their expectant stares, he consciously put on a pompous smirk, puffing out his chest in an attempt to project confidence.

As he approached the house, his hand trembled, hovering over the door handle. The cabinet began to slowly creak open.

LUKA CHHIPI [HIDE AND SEEK]

Damini's mellow eyes, laden with kajal, met another set of outlined eyes. 'Nooo! we lost again'' Geeta's little voice sighed. However, these eyes weren't her Baba's; they were cold-blue. Just one word escaped Damini's trembling lips, "Please."

Farhan's gaze fell on Geeta's little form huddled in the cramped space, clutching onto her gudiya tightly. His hand stretched out towards Geeta, and simply patted her doll's head. In that moment, the icy glaciers in the depths of those eyes seemed to melt away, revealing something that defied their chilly exterior.

Not far away, the leader of the mob screamed, "Farhan, koi mila?" (Farhan, did you find anyone?)

"No, the house is empty. Let's move ahead."

By Parthivi Kapur
Year 11
Sardar Patel Vidyalaya
New Delhi, India

Writing about empathy led me to realise its presence in the subtlest of gestures, from a mere nod to decisive choices which yield profound consequences. It can hide in something as simple as a verbal yes or no, yet lead to something as tangled as a war or as noble as saving a life. This exploration, helped me in gaining insight into its complex layers and the significance of acknowledging richly empathetic acts.

- Parthivi Kapur

EMPATHY:

A key 🔑element of Emotional Intelligence
A key 🔑 ingredient of better relationships

Engaging students in practising Empathy in project-based and problem-based education helps children to become self-disciplined and empathetic architects of their destiny.

A MILLION IN ONE: FINDING EMPATHY IN CRISIS

I opened my eyes.

White, fluorescent lights instantly blinded me. Squinting, I could make out the smiling but worried faces of my parents and an army of masked doctors and nurses alongside them. It took me a moment, but everything came flooding back.

The year 2020 will forever be etched in my memory as one of the most turbulent times of my young life, but not for the same reasons as for any other teen. While the world grappled with COVID-19, I struggled with dizziness, nausea and intense headaches.

'Cranio... what?'

'Craniopharyngioma.' the doctor said. 'It'a a tumour, essentially, pressing here.' He gestured to a point on the tens of MRI scans that lay strewn on his desk, revealing the insidious mass invading my brain. 'It'll have to be operated on.'

We were dealing with something with odds of one in a million. None of us had any idea what to expect and I kept asking – why me? The days that followed are now a blur, but living through each hour then felt like a lifetime. However, it was during the days that followed my diagnosis that I experienced empathy of the highest order from everyone associated.

I was in the middle of my Grade 7 exams when this diagnosis came through. Naturally, my parents informed my school. My principal understood the situation and exempted me from appearing for the remaining tests.

"He's going through so much, at such a young age. Focus on getting better, and we'll deal with the tests later," she had said with a smile. In her own small way, she empathised with me and understood what it took to take exams in such a difficult situation.

With my school cheering me on, I felt unstoppable. Immediately after the surgery, I had ten tubes, perhaps more, emerging from several parts of my body. Sleeping with so many contraptions attached to me in the cold ICU was nearly impossible. I was all alone and missed my parents terribly since they were allowed to visit me only at certain times of the day. In those times, the nurses would stay up and regale me with stories from their hometowns and how even they missed their friends and parents back home.

Through my entire ordeal, my parents were the ones who lived the whole experience beside me. Every time I winced as a needle penetrated my skin, they too felt the pain. They recognised what a tough time it was for me and did their best to keep me positive and energised at all times. At mealtimes, they would take turns reading to me by my bedside and despite the circumstances, those are some of my most cherished memories.

The kindness and understanding I experienced from everyone through this ordeal has instilled in me a profound realisation; putting myself in the shoes of people I'm dealing with, looking at situations from their viewpoint and a few kind words go a long way in making the world a better place.

This is a true story based on my experience of dealing with a serious medical condition. Though this was the toughest time of my life, due to the empathy I experienced from everyone imaginable, it remains one of my most cherished memories.

- Riaan Rao

By Riaan Rao
Year 10
Don Bosco International School
Mumbai, India

CAPTURED: A SNAPSHOT FROM THE STOLEN GENERATION, AUSTRALIA

Australia 1950

My hands quivered as I was seized by the icy tendrils of my captor. My reflection was caught in the wing mirror of a disintegrating, rusty, once pristine and shining silver car. As I gained momentum, I captured a glimpse of a dead tree through the heat haze in the distance, silhouetted like a solitary soldier amongst the moving landscape. My heart was bursting out of my chest; I felt like I couldn't breathe, suffocating in my scrambled thoughts. The red desert was no more, evaporating in front of me. A lifeless, desolate plateau of nothingness. Crimson, velvety microbes of dust turned towards luminous lights, blinding, neon high-rises and towering buildings, staring down at my pathetic, puny form with a dismissive frown. I am utterly overwhelmed by their unfamiliarity.

Without warning, I was shoved forcefully into a bleak and hostile environment. It lacked that same comforting, warm, blanket-like feeling. I could still feel my mother's fresh, dewy tears on my back as they wrenched me roughly from her grasp. I will never forget the terrified look on her face, an unimaginable scene playing out before her stupefied gaze. I could never forget my native home, the scent of rain on the gum leaves and the sound of the black cockatoos squawking their early morning chorus. These memories comforted and reassured me as I thought of them; a calm landscape of serenity to settle my shattered emotions. I was utterly dumbstruck by how they would perform such a reckless and unprovoked act towards me.

Tomorrow, I was hoping to be freed forever from this claustrophobic cell of emotions. Although my thoughts were racing rapidly, I had been a good, virtuous and unselfish individual for the majority of my life. What reasons did they have to take away my culture, my language, my family, my deeply ingrained roots and my proud history? I was truly perplexed. Why did they do this? Questions unanswered, my inner voice destroyed, my life gone. My family was torn apart. Why is life like this? My life is not my own. No ancient dreamtime stories at bedtime; no wisdom passed down from generations of elders.

They feared my indigenous roots, my unique voice. They feared me telling my own story; they wanted to change everything about me and make me one of them. A soulless, mindless, vacuum; an automaton, an entity. A number, not an individual.

By Ruby hand
Year 6
Trinity Lutheran College
Gold Coast, Queensland, Australia

I had been studying the Stolen Generation at School and was moved by the plight of our indigenous people. This made me want to write about what I thought it might have been like for them. I think it is atrocious and never should have happened.

- Ruby Hand

WHY COMPASSIONATE EMPATHY IS IMPERATIVE FOR PERSONAL AND SOCIETAL DEVELOPMENT

Why empathy matters?

Human development depends on the nourishment of our interpersonal relationships, contingent on empathy (Hirn, Thomas, & Zoelch 2018). Empathy's importance is instilled into us from youth, as we are constantly instructed to empathise with our peers or siblings by forlorn teachers or parents. Despite this, we content ourselves with an intuitive and fuzzy understanding of this crucial but nebulous concept. In reality, empathy is an archipelago of related but distinct concepts referring to the ability to understand, recognise and resonate with the experience of others (Lockwood, Ang, Husain & Crockett, 2017; Cuff, Brown, Taylor & Howett, 2014). The evasiveness of a single definition of empathy, combined with extensive psychological and neuroscientific research, has led to its deconstruction into connected but dissociable concepts (Cuff, Brown, et al, 2014).

Cognitive empathy is the ability to understand the feelings of another and is characterised by 'mentalising' – taking the perspective of another person, though not their emotional state. (Decety, Bartal, Uzefovsky & Knafo-Noam, 2016). Emotional empathy goes beyond understanding and refers to the ability to share the emotions of another person by observing their emotional state (Thomson, van Reekum & Chakrabati, 2021). Finally, compassionate empathy is the combination of these two which drives us to alleviate another's suffering (Powell and Roberts, 2017).

Viewed through the lens of the mother-daughter relationship – where empathy can represent the greatest necessity, but also the greatest challenge – we can analyse how these different concepts can exist separately. For example, a mother displaying cognitive empathy may be able to understand the perspective of her frustrated daughter, who pushes against the confines of maternal protection in a bid for freedom and individuality, but may fail to feel those feelings of restriction and enclosure herself that would arise from emotional empathy. Conversely, a mother may see her daughter cry and feel the same sadness overwhelm her own body and mind, even if the daughter's refusal to open up precludes her mother from understanding her daughter's perspective. As we see, cognitive empathy without emotional empathy is cold, and emotional empathy without cognitive empathy is helpless.

But these disparate sparks of empathy light the fire that is the human spirit, the pinnacle of our being which manifests as compassionate empathy, uniting two key aspects of what it means to be human – understanding and emotion – and driving us to help others. As the mother sees her daughter drowning in the open waters of adolescent anxiety – educational pressures, peer pressures, societal pressures – she recognises and immediately comprehends the universal experiences that her daughter faces, for every human must feel the weight of these timeless struggles.

WHY COMPASSIONATE EMPATHY IS IMPERATIVE FOR PERSONAL AND SOCIETAL DEVELOPMENT

This conceptual understanding transforms into feeling the same tightness in her chest that her daughter feels, the serpent of apprehension constricting her as it coils around her ribcage. This emotion then transforms into action as the mother – if she is anything like my wonderful mother – alleviates the pressure by comforting her daughter and letting her know she is not alone in her difficulties.

Such empathy need not – indeed it must not – be confined to mother-daughter relationships. The dissociation of empathy into its constituent concepts presents an opportunity to recognise empathy as skills that can be developed, rather than a mere platitude we tell each other. We can learn to better see the perspectives of others (Hayden et al 2021) and introspect to better feel how they feel (Weisz et al 2020), and in doing so cultivate the urge to help others. In a world desolated by anger, misunderstanding, and conflict, being an empathetic individual is like throwing stones into water; the ripples of our impact are felt far and wide.

By Rudritara Shroff
Year 11
American School of Bombay
Mumbai, India



The pinnacle of my writing process revolved around delving into the psychological dimension of empathy, which held a profound fascination for me as a passionate psychology enthusiast with aspirations to study both psychology and art in medicine at university.

- Rudritara Shroff

EMPATHY: THE SHAPESHIFTER

Empathy is a skill. It is the ability to understand the thoughts and feelings of those around us, which we use to put ourselves into their shoes. In some ways, it connects us with the world and the emotions that make it turn.

Empathy has three types: compassionate, cognitive, and emotional. Simply put, compassionate empathy is empathy in action. When we extend our aid to people in need, compassionate empathy comes into play. Cognitive empathy is the ability to detect another's feelings. It is the first layer of empathy on which the other two rest. Lastly, emotional empathy is "when you feel physically along with the other person, as though their emotions were contagious." (Goleman, D. (2011). Different kinds of empathy. Key Step Media.)

Experiences and empathy combine throughout our lifetime to build our ideals, ethics, and character. If a person is suffering, cognitive empathy allows us to detect this suffering, and compassionate empathy spurs us to extend a helping hand. However, the involvement of emotional empathy is more complex. If a child witnesses a person performing an activity, the child tends to associate that person's emotions with the activity. As children instinctually gravitate towards joy, they tend to perform activities they associate with it.

These ideas portray empathy as a guru within, which guides the actions and ideals of the individual. As a mentor of the character, it holds tremendous influence over our words, deeds, and thoughts. The Japanese explore these ideas through Omoiyari, the concept of empathy and consideration. This idea is embedded within Japanese society and is inculcated in children early on. By exposing them to a compassionate society, Japan has enabled the growth of empathy within their youth, allowing them to develop respect, insight, and a drive to better their community. I experienced firsthand the empathy of the Japanese people when I visited the country. The citizens went so far as to draw maps for us and walk us to train stations to ensure we would find our way.

However, the severe want of empathy in the present is as plain as day. Acts of kindness, words of understanding, or thoughts of consideration are lacking in the vast majority. As a teenager going into high school, I had not expected the weight of my actions to be so crushing. Every step I took was scrutinized by the many eyes trained on me. Each one judged, calculated, and whispered, till I convinced myself that their standards were more suffocating than I could take. My first panic attack was in high school, and every relapse came with a fresh bout of judgement. Part of the blame goes to the society that did not have the empathy to withhold their judgement. Even with the thousands of teenagers having the same problem, society cannot deign to grant us the bare minimum, the empathy of silence, that could have prevented our conditions.

EMPATHY: THE SHAPESHIFTER

Empathy holds the power to change the world. Mahatma Gandhi exemplified this. To understand the situation of the lower class, when he returned to India, he abandoned his barrister's collar for a loincloth and took part in their activities by establishing the Sabarmati Ashram. He welcomed the so-called "untouchables" with open arms, a revolutionary step for that time, and christened them the Harijans (Children of God). Without the progress he facilitated using his empathy, the caste system might have been unchanged today.

Whether to build the characters of our youth, mend our society, or eradicate the regressive ideas of yesteryear, empathy is a shapeshifter that we can wield to create a better tomorrow.

By Saachi Khandeparkar
Year 11
Bombay Scottish School, Mahim (India)
Mumbai, India

The highlight of writing this essay was the process of truly understanding empathy and its multiple dimensions. Though we use the word frequently, there is so much more to it than meets the eye.

- Saachi Khandeparkar



THE SOUND OF EMPATHY

Aashvi revelled in the earthy scent of the park. Despite her gruelling job, she persisted in relishing the peace it held. A frail woman was slumped beside her. Often, Aashvi found her ruminating there in silence. That day, however, was an exception.

“I remember coming here a year ago with my son and listening to the ensemble that gathered here”, she mumbled. Observing the woman’s face, Aashvi sensed a wistful melancholy she hadn’t seen before. This, more than anything, motivated her to listen.

“That was my best memory with him, although every moment with him was precious.” She blinked, attempting to eradicate the emotions plaguing her. “What a way to quit the world, to void me of family, love, and that smile of his.”

She laughed mirthlessly. “Grief is a funny thing. You think it’s faded into the background, and then it hits without mercy. Today’s his birthday, and it aches. I should be too numb for this, but it aches.”

The words encompassed Aashvi, dragging the emotions through her. She had never known such grief, but the suffering of this woman, aged less than forty, pained her.

“If I could have the past in my grasp, I’d hold him close. I’d pinch his cheeks, sing him the birthday song, and fight tooth and claw to keep him beside me.”

At this point, her eyes were glazed, and though she looked at Aashvi, her gaze went beyond, to some vision past the material.

“God, bring him back. For just a second, bring him back to me.”

When she didn’t speak again, Aashvi wordlessly rose from her seat. She retreated from the woman who cocooned in memories, hardly noticing her departure.

Aashvi’s supervisor received a message that day about her needing leave from work. She didn’t feel much remorse; more pressing matters spurred her as she called some acquaintances for an urgent favour, and hurried home.

The lady was still reminiscing when a clear note rang through the park. It was followed by another, then another until sound swelled through the crisp winter air. It began to permeate her senses. As the music came alive, her eyes widened. The piece, though different, had a similar cadence, and she lifted her face to its beauty, as tears spilled down her cheeks.

She was in the past. Her boy sat on her lap, swaying to the music. For a second, his tender hands grasped hers as he whispered, “Mama, listen closely. It’ll take you

THE SOUND OF EMPATHY

wherever you want to be!”

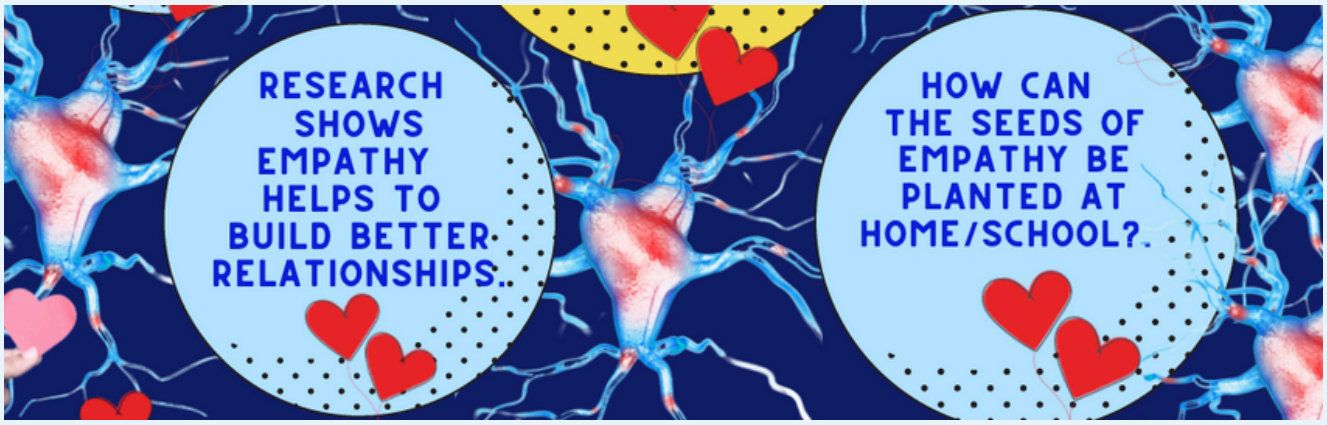
The melody ceased, and he was gone. The woman looked at the violinist leading the ensemble as the troupe bowed. Aashvi regarded the mother with gentle understanding, bowed directly to her, and left without reply. The mother nodded softly in return, unable to exert herself beyond this, as the gratitude stole her voice and the experience rendered her motionless.

Phantoms of the music tickled her ears, and despite herself, she smiled at the sky. “Happy Birthday, son”, she said and left the park.

By Saachi Khandeparkar
Year 11
Bombay Scottish School, Mahim (India)
Mumbai, India

My highlight was immersing myself in the stories and its characters while writing it.

- Saachi Khandeparkar



OUR RIGHT TO EDUCATION

“I-N-T-E-R-N-A-S-H-U-N-A-L”. The shy 12-year-old was trying his best to spell “international”, but just couldn’t get it right. This was met with a roar of laughter from the class.

Every day, Karan was teased mercilessly. Ever since joining the school, he was relentlessly tormented due to his background but Karan’s unwavering need for approval was bewildering. I was always stuck between a rock and a hard place as the bullies had been my first-grade buddies and siding with them was my natural instinct. I tried cutting Karan some slack, but years of friendship and loyalty clouded my judgment.

Seeing Karan’s usually smiling features crumple like paper made me furious. I stormed out of the class. Anger and guilt waged a war in my head, fighting between loyalty and righteousness. They welcomed me when I first joined, what’s so bad about Karan?

I picked up a ball and made my way towards the hoops. I smashed the ball on the board. What is wrong with these guys? I smashed another ball. Why does Karan try so hard? I was lost in my thoughts when my friends entered laughing like hyenas after a kill.

“Hey! Why did you storm off? ”, shouted one of them.

“You should’ve seen us, we made that kid cry!” said another.

This was my breaking point. A wave of anger engulfed me and I needed to shut them up.

“Stop!”, I screamed.

“Stop what?” they asked, puzzled.

“Stop the torture test, the cruelty, and targeting Karan!”. “Is that what you are angry about? That loser Karan? That kid doesn’t belong here!”

“Do you not know what Right to Education is?”, I countered.

They stared at each other in shock, “Can you believe this guy?”

“Yes, he can’t speak English and is in our school due to a government initiative, but that doesn’t give you any right to bully him. All he wants is acceptance and understanding, he just wants to be treated fairly!”

OUR RIGHT TO EDUCATION

“Yes, he can’t speak English and is in our school due to a government initiative, but that doesn’t give you any right to bully him. All he wants is acceptance and understanding, he just wants to be treated fairly!”

“If he wants acceptance he needs to work for it and stand up for himself.”, another chimed in, “Maybe learn some spellings too.”

This caused them to howl with laughter so I decided to hit them where it hurt.

“You!”, I pointed, ”You can’t even add? And you...”, I questioned another, ”Don’t even get me started on your football skills. Who are you to judge?”

I spotted Karan passing by, and I made my decision. I left the others as I called out to Karan and left without a glance.

Karan looked nervous as I put an arm around his shoulder. I noticed his tear-stained face and thought I needed to say something.

“Hey, you know you don’t need them, right? Why do you put up with their insults, you know you don’t need their acceptance. Why don’t you give them a taste of their own medicine?”

Karan said,” I know I don’t need their acceptance. I could hit back, but then there would be no difference between me and them.”

By Shaan Shah
Year 7
Symbiosis International School
Pune, India

I had a great experience writing this story since it made me reflect on what empathy actually is. It made me think about the times I or someone else was empathetic and how it affected other people. My highlight was the idea itself. This was because the incident was close to me since it is based on something that had happened in my school some time ago and it tells of how it would be to stand up for someone.

- Shaan Shah

EMPATHY: IS IT HARDWIRED INTO OUR BIOLOGY?

“The Upanishads, an Indian philosophical text written in the 5th Century BCE say 'See all beings in Self and the Self in all beings'. To me, this epitomises the meaning of empathy. At its core, Empathy means the ability to feel others' feelings and use that understanding to guide our actions.

Do these feelings relate only to other humans? A phrase from the Upanishads - Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam is a Sanskrit Phrase meaning 'The World is one Family'. At its core, it emphasises considering everything in the world - not just humans but the earth itself as one family. It encourages prioritising the well-being of this family over individual interests.

Is this behaviour alien to us? Living beings are intrinsically social. Our lives and the joys we experience depend on social interactions.. We are motivated to form and maintain positive relationships. Scientists believe that empathy is biologically hardwired in all living beings.

From infancy, humans show an innate empathetic response, such as mirroring facial expressions and demonstrating distress when they see others in pain. In 2007, Paul Bloom and his colleagues conducted a study in which they found that babies as young as six months old were able to differentiate between happy and sad facial expressions, proving that they feel cognitive empathy. Infants showed signs of distress when they saw others in distress, an example of emotional empathy.

Other studies in humans have shown that mere perception of another individual's pain activates the pain-related neural network in the observer, as though the observer was experiencing pain. These neural networks have Mirror Neurons, specialised cells in the brain that fire signals when we see another person acting. Brain imaging techniques have found increased activity in the Mirror Neurons when we empathise with other people's pain or joy.

The mimicking of the response by the observer’s Mirror Neurons is responsible for our ability to perceive the feelings of other people. Mirror Neurons serve as a neural pathway for empathy, bridging the gap between self and others. This indicates that empathy is hardwired into our neural circuitry and has evolutionary roots, emerging as a survival strategy for our species.

These evolutionary roots extend beyond humans to all living beings. Studies on apes, dolphins and even trees have shown that they exhibit behaviour indicative of empathy such as comforting distressed individuals sharing resources and protecting each other.

EMPATHY: IS IT HARDWIRED INTO OUR BIOLOGY?

As part of a societal outreach initiative, I work with an orphanage in Bangalore, India. Over the past year, I have spent time with the children in the orphanage supporting them with food, medical checkups and educational support. Compassionate empathy has driven me into action and helped me mobilise other like-minded people to support the children. I have realised that people are naturally empathetic, and willing to step forward and do their best.

Empathy is not a behaviour that needs to be learnt. It is an intrinsic aspect of human nature and biology. It is a part of our evolutionary history and is embedded in our neural circuitry. By harnessing this feeling, we can make the world a beautiful place; as expressed by this quote from the Upanishads.

"The World Is A Family
One Is A Relative,
The Other Stranger,
Say The Small Minded.
The Entire World Is A Family,
Live The Magnanimous."

By Siddhartha Suhas
Year 10
Deutsche Schule Bombay (DSB)
Mumbai, India

I really enjoyed researching and writing the essay. Discussing this with my parents, friends and teachers gave me a great opportunity to exchange opinions and ideas, sharpen my thinking and present my case. Overall it was a very enriching and thought provoking experience.

- Siddhartha Suhas



CURSED ANGEL

Demon. Alien. Possessed. In sniggers and sly remarks and cruel pieces of paper with my name scrawled. They wrote on glass shards that pierced me until I bled out. Now I was a skeleton.
The worst of the names was Freak. Now it was being passed around the class like a scornful laugh.
And that was all I heard- the raucous cacophony of laughter. Time froze.

There I was. Suspended.

My body moved of its own accord; I was an observer. I watched as the frail slender arms of a scrawny boy went limp as a rag doll; his eyes glazed over.
That's all I was- a rag doll. The demon manipulates the strings of this useless puppet to dance for my classmates. They cackle in glee.
That's my epilepsy. This curse.
All I remember is fading from drinking an obsidian multiverse of floating lanterns, tourmaline, and amethyst, finally unfettered, to my real galaxy.
Half an hour later, I was walking, head bowed, on the cobbled pavement.
I felt Aryan's claw dig into my flesh, brutish face ecstatically red. He roared, "Did you see him? He fell asleep!" His laugh got lost in tens of others as a crowd collected.

His tone grew imperial. "I think we should punish him for pretending to have this weird disease."

Calls of agreement rang out like a death knell.
Piya, a burly girl, stormed out of the spattering.
Next thing I knew, Aryan was muffling my voice with an iron grip as Piya swiped through my bag.

"Ooh, what's this?" she giggled in a tinkling, plastic voice, grabbing the lunch box Mumma had packed.
The one Mumma gave me for my birthday. With the Star Wars characters on it.

I don't watch Star Wars anymore.

It's still my favourite lunch box because it's from her.
Piya sneered. "Oooh, baby watch Star Wars."
closed my eyes. "Don't do anything... please!"
Piya laughed. It was laced with thorns.

She walked to the pond.

I saw it in slow motion.

CURSED ANGEL

She began emptying the contents, and then she tossed the lunch box into the weed and muck. She dusted her hands, proud of her work, and the little group walked off, sniggering.
Leaving me in their dust.
I just wanted to be friends with them.
Half an hour later, I was still crouched there. My tears bounced off the little pebbles and into puddles. I was a baby.
I heard footsteps getting louder behind me.
I whipped my head around, prepared for the worst.

That's not what I saw.

A plump, shivering boy. Covered head to toe in swamp slime. Hair plastered to his forehead.

"Hi. I'm Rohan..." He revealed a small, grubby muffin, panting.

"I saw you missed lunch... this was all I could steal."
His face was blue. But his eyes sparkled.

As water ran down his chubby cheeks, he smiled, and it was the purest smile I had ever seen.

For in one proud hand, he held a muddy wet lunch box.

By Tanisha Desai
Year 11
Dhirubhai Ambani International School
Mumbai, India

I think the highlight was definitely interviewing the son of a friend of my mother's, who has epilepsy. He was diagnosed at age eight and is currently twelve. It was so enlightening to learn more about it and one of the main reasons I wrote my story about him was because of how little we know or talk about epilepsy. About 50 million people have epilepsy, making it an extremely common affliction that isn't discussed nearly enough. I was so curious to learn about his experiences and how different his world is from mine.
- Tanisha Desai

PAY IT FORWARD

In the heart of Mumbai, amidst the chaos and despair of India's largest garbage dumping ground in Govandi, my unconventional narrative on empathy unfolded. It happened when I was a fresh volunteer with my mother at Pratham, an NGO devoted to alleviating the harsh realities of the most marginalized communities through education. This led me to a daunting landscape of India's largest garbage dumping grounds, that would redefine my understanding of resilience and compassion.

As I nervously traversed through slum alleys at the garbage grounds, two extraordinary volunteers emerged from the shadows within the maze of refuse, toxins, and despair, as they embarked on a daily mission that transcended the limits of empathy.

This unlikely duo, a Muslim girl and a Hindu boy, navigate the treacherous garbage mountains to rescue children exposed to the dangers of scavenging. Their relentless mission: to pull these children away from sifting through towering refuse, offering them a chance at education.

Remarkably, they perform their work entirely voluntarily. When I enquire about compensation, they reveal that their sole motivation is to pay forward the opportunity they received. They recounted the story of their transformation from despair to hope. Slum children and rag pickers themselves received an opportunity for education through the same NGO that I was working with.

The impact of studying through the organization, Pratham, was life-changing. Born into abject poverty, education became their transformative force, offering skills that not only changed their destinies but uplifted their families from the clutches of destitution. Now, with the same fervour, they are committed to rescuing others.

The children they save are not just escaping the dangers of the garbage dump; they are breaking free from the cycle of poverty that threatens to consume them. The volunteers, fueled by the memory of their salvation, are determined to be the catalysts for change in these young lives.

Meeting these selfless individuals, whose commitment transcended mere altruism, stirred deep emotions within me. Their story, a symphony of empathy and self-motivated responsibility, became a living testament to the profound truth that empathy can be found in the unlikeliest corners.

As I stand on top of a towering garbage mountain, the acrid stench of decaying waste assaulting my senses, I see piles of discarded debris stretch endlessly in every direction. Amidst the disarray, the occasional glint of sunlight catches on shards of broken glass, reflecting a harsh reality beneath the layers of discarded lives.

PAY IT FORWARD

It's here, amidst the overwhelming panorama of penury, that I realize the profound impact that empathy, translated into action, can have on the world. These two volunteers, emerging from the darkest corners, embody the potential for change within us all. If a pair of 19-year-olds, irrespective of gender or religion differences, from a garbage dumping ground in Govandi, can sow the seeds of hope and transformation, then imagine what can be achieved if everyone embraces the responsibility to pay it forward and contribute in their way?

By Varun Bakshi
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Writing about EMPATHY provided a platform for reflection, allowing me to contemplate personal experiences and consider how I could channel those insights into aiding others and reshaping narratives.

- Varun Bakshi



THE SENTIMENT BEHIND EMPATHY

We think of empathy as “putting ourselves in someone else’s shoes.” It is defined in the Oxford English Dictionary as “the power of mentally identifying oneself with (and so fully comprehending) a person or object of contemplation, similar to the Greek pathos.” So, what is empathy, and what makes it important?

The first (popular) definition makes us think about a similar emotion: pity. At first, it seems similar to empathy, for it shares in common the feature of feeling (yourself) the feelings of another. However, pity only involves doing this when the other person is in an unfortunate state of mind. Our happiness is reduced slightly by their situation, but notably, we do not do anything to redeem the situation. On the surface, this seems similar to empathy but has the wrong sentiment, and so is not similar. Empathy involves feeling the feelings of the other, regardless of their mental state. If they are feeling unhappy, we feel bad with them and not for them. The other side of empathy is feeling happy for the other person when they are in a good situation, even if they are not. This characteristic is what makes empathy so powerful, more than pity can ever be. While pity reduces the total happiness among people, empathy increases it; empathy makes the other person feel better (which in turn makes our conscience feel better) when they are unhappy and makes us feel better when the other party is happy! But does it always do so? If we are empathetic from a sense of duty, eventually we may tire it could even lead to us becoming annoyed when someone is unhappy (which is, of course, not empathetic!). On the other hand, if we are empathetic for the express purpose of making others happy, it would naturally make us happier too.

True friendships need empathy because it puts both parties on a level playing field, revealing the innermost emotional qualities of each. Even if they have something in common and get along well, neither of them can know how the other thinks without empathy. It ties people together without a specific reason, transcending rationality. Empathy is giving something unconditionally.

Families lead to relationships in a similar vein, if stronger. For those of the same generation, perhaps empathy is easiest because they go through the same ordeals. For example, yesterday when I saw my younger brother being treated unfairly, I remembered going through the same situation when I was his age, without anyone to support me, and so I silently supported him. It rested my conscience, and I can only assume that my brother was slightly comforted.

Empathy is like contentment in that it is not outwardly visible or measurable, but when it is present it improves everyone’s lives. In that, it is a symbol of a healthy life. Empathy is not just about feeling for another person, but the sentiment behind it.

THE SENTIMENT BEHIND EMPATHY

It is undoubtedly important individually but on a societal scale, empathy compounds – almost like vaccinations. In our world, bound as it is by necessity and divided by choices and circumstances, empathy is the connective tissue we need to know we are not alone.

By Vedant Venkatesh
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My highlight was thinking deeply about empathy and the conclusions that emerged from it. Before then, I had always just thought empathy was a good think to have, and never thought any more of the matter. The most challenging part was definitely fitting my ideas into the word limit.

- Vedant Venkatesh



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Write a Short Empathy Story or Essay (Fiction or Non-Fiction, we accept BOTH)

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